

Equal to the TEST

They are children of marginal farmers, petty shop-owners and jobless people. Yet nothing has come in the way of these young men from Bihar as they reach for the stars.

Photographs by RANJAN RAO



ASHOK KUMAR, 18

OBC RANK 1,755

The son of a railway official, Ashok shares a one-room house with his family of five in a noisy neighbourhood, right next to a bus stand, where drunken brawls happen every night. Electricity is an infrequent visitor but these daily deprivations failed to deter him from clearing the IIT entrance test. All he wanted was enough money to buy books but he didn't always have that either.

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

Rahul Sharma's family of four stays together in a single room where the mother cooks on a gas cylinder kept at a safe distance from her son's study table. The old refrigerator his father purchased during "the good days" no longer works. Noisy fights in the neighbourhood liquor shop provide daily distractions while his mother's clothes, usually worn and washed many times over, are a source of continuing agony for this 17-year-old at family gatherings where everyone sports their best. Yet, Rahul, the son of a computer operator who earns just Rs 3,000 a month, has overcome his environment and indeed his destiny to rank 398 in the Other Backward Classes (OBC) category and 2,921 in the overall merit list of the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) entrance test in his very first attempt.

Years ago, Rahul had watched his father struggle to save his typing training institute in Gaya district from extortionists. He finally closed it down and moved to Patna where he gradually sold all his typewriters to finance his son's study. Rahul's story of hardship and hardwork is heartwarming but not unique. There are many others from equally modest or even humbler backgrounds in Bihar who cracked the country's highly competitive prestigious Joint Entrance Examination (JEE) for the IITS.

Sample this: Ashok Kumar, 18, is the son of a railway employee, Ranvijay Prasad Singh, who earns Rs 5,000 a month, not enough for his family of five. Ashok lives with his two brothers in a one-room shack made of bricks and a tin-roof. A wooden cot in the veranda serves as his study table. It is close to a bus stand where the drunken revelry of abusive ticket agents is a constant source of commotion. He's had to study by the light of a lantern when some anti-socials snapped the electricity wire, which saw the locality go without power for over a week. Surprisingly, however, he does not think these to be "real troubles". "What really bothered me was that I had no money to purchase books and IIT study material," says Ashok. Nothing, however, could stop him from cracking the IIT this year. In his second attempt, Ashok has finished at 1,755 in the OBC category.

It's no mean feat for anyone, considering that this year 3,84,977 students from all over India competed for 8,295 seats in the